

Napster reborn

Popular music downloading service Napster launches app for Apple iPhone, iPad and iPod Touch

SATA 6 SSD

PhotoFast to launch 470MB/s SATA 6.0 SSD drive in October

traditional compact cameras is blurring. DSLRs, which were considered the domain of professionals, a few years back, are now also targeting first time users with entry level offerings.

To cut a long story short, you have to be very sure of *why* you want the camera. If you are just buying a camera for casual use, then the hassle free point and shoots are enough. For the more adventurous types, who are willing to play around with the settings and want to shoot outdoors, or those who aim to buy DSLR in the future, but want to acquaint themselves with the basics first, the ultra-zooms are the answer.

DSLR cameras are ideal for people who will invest a lot of time in photography. Higher-end DSLRs are meant for professionals, and are priced accordingly. Only buy them if you know what you're doing, and will use all the features.

THE TECHNOLOGY

Touchscreens are seen on many compact cameras recently and the trend is definitely on the rise if the interest level on Google is any indication to go by. But having tested many touchscreen cameras, we feel that actual button feedback is better – touchscreens do not really help in any-

way, and are more of a gimmick.

Like touch-screens, **geo-tagging** is another feature that found its way from cell phones into cameras. Although many high-end cameras had this functionality some years back, you can find it in quite a few compact cameras today. If you travel a lot, this is a good feature to have, ₹15,000 to ₹20,000 is the ideal price point for ultrazooms with geo tagging.

Although this is not exactly a new trend as such, but we are seeing new **card formats** like SDXC, Eye Fi cards flooding the market. So when you buy a camera be doubly sure of what memory format it supports. Ideally we would not recommend cameras that only support proprietary formats (read Sony's memory stick). It is best to stick to standard SD and SDHC cards and buy a camera which is compatible with future SDXC card formats. For DSLRs the standard is the CF card, but a lot of higher-end DSLRs also support CF and SD cards. Eye-Fi cards have a Wi-Fi adapter inbuilt,



The Micro Four Thirds sensor based Olympus PEN E-P1

which allows wireless image transfer, but it is expensive.

Olympus and Panasonic came out with the **micro four thirds** image sensor which allows you have a more compact DSLR. The micro four third image sensor reduces the space between the lens mount and the sensor along with doing away with the mirror box which reflects light to the viewfinder. The result is a much compact DSLR with interchangeable lenses. The lens diameter opening is reduced somewhat but you can use normal lenses with the help of an adapter.

Many cameras are slowly but surely adopting this technology. It is aimed at photographers who want the quality of a DSLR but in a compact form factor. We have used such cameras in our comparison tests, and they were good in certain

BRAND BUSTING

The eternal war of Canon vs. Nikon continues as always, but a Google Insight for search threw up some interesting results. To be fair to all cameras, we just put in a term with the brand name like Canon, Nikon, Sony, Samsung and Panasonic. As can be seen in the graphs, the interest around Canon and Sony in India was very comparable in 2008 and 2009, but in 2010, Nikon is catching up thanks to its range of entry-level cameras, a segment which was dominated by Canon and Sony all these years. In comparison to these three behemoths, Samsung and Panasonic attract lesser search terms. But one look at the growth relative to industry throws up Samsung as the winner with its curiosity level rising way above the others thanks to the aggressive shipment of cameras

across the entry level and prosumer category. Other brands like Olympus and Fujifilm had a very low interest level so we did not include them in the top 5.



Graphs comparing the popularity and growth of camera companies

In the compact camera market, Sony leads with a 45 per cent share whereas Canon has a 20% share whereas in the DSLR segment Canon is the leader with a 55 per cent share followed by Nikon which covers around 40 per cent. Having mentioned the leaders, it is also important to know that other manufacturers like Samsung, Panasonic etc are also ramping up their camera production and marketing in India. According to industry figures, camera unit sales is expected to touch 1.8 million pieces by year end.